

UNDERCOVER

Operation PC Cabinet

Agent 001 is out on the field once again, this time on the trail of the usually neglected but all-important PC cabinet

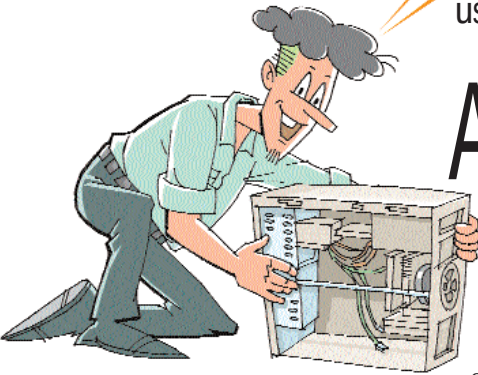


Illustration: Mahesh Benkar

There is a distinct move towards ATX and Micro-ATX cabinets, which can be bought for as little as Rs 1,400

Another month, another operation. This time I was hard on the trail of PC cabinets—much ignored, but something your system cannot do without. Some of you might drool over them, but most think it does not make a farthing of a difference. The primary criterion for most computer buyers in India while selecting a cabinet is that it should not add to the cost of the system in any significant manner.

Strangely enough, in India, PC cabinets come equipped with power supply—Switch Mode Power Supply (SMPS). But although that's how the market offers them, manufacturers generally ship them separately. So while buying a cabinet if you feel it has an underpowered power supply, you can get it changed.

I set 'Operation PC Cabinet' into motion at Goregaon, at a large cabinet dealer's showroom. According to him, cabinets from Mercury were popular and cheap. You could buy a cabinet for the smaller Baby AT motherboards that uses the older power supply system for less than Rs 800. He added that lately there was a distinct move towards ATX and Micro-ATX cabinets, which could be bought for as low as Rs 1,400. ATX cabinets are available in a variety of colours and shapes and depending on the power supply used, the cost can go as high as Rs 4,000. Most of his sales came from assemblers. On the rare occasions that users approached him directly, they argued over relatively less important details like colour, and never over power supply.

The most discerning buyers, he said, were people building servers or other high-end computers

who came with specific models and power supply ratings.

Next, I shifted base to some shops in Andheri. At one I asked for a cabinet with a power supply that would support an AMD processor, which is recommended to be fitted only with a 300-watt power supply. The dealer did not know of any such special power supply. All his cabinets were equipped with a power supply of 235 watt. He quickly added that he had not heard of any complaints from customers in this regard.

I moved on to a shop that sold only P4-based systems. P4 systems use cases with a different type of power supply and are rather expensive, ranging from Rs 2,500 to Rs 3,500, but this was more than made up for by their build quality. The dealer told me that Mercury had some really inexpensive cabinets for Pentium 4 that complied with all the new ATX regulations and retailed for under Rs 2,500.

My final destination for this mission was Lamington Road, Mumbai's 'Destination Hardware'. I asked the dealer in one of the shops here whether he could find me a case with a 400-watt power supply. I amazed to hear him say: "Pick any cabinet and we will fit it with a power supply that will match your requirements". According to him, Indian power supplies were nothing to scoff at and supplied clean and pure voltages as compared to some of the cheaper types coming in from Taiwan and elsewhere. He also recommended the KOB series of cabinets from Mercury, saying they were probably the best when it came to affordable cabinets, especially the KOB31. This model, with a semi-transparent front facia (a first here) was sold for about Rs 1,550. The fit and finish of the KOB series, he claimed, was top quality and the power supply too was rated at a decent 250 watt—sufficient for most computer systems.

Another dealer offered me an irresistible option—he could modify any cabinet of my choice. He had photographs of several modified cabinets—cabinets with gaping holes covered by fibre glass shields, extra large fans and neon lights glowing inside, and so on. He said a modification could cost a customer anywhere between Rs 2,000 and Rs 3,000 extra, depending on his requirements.

Well, mission accomplished. My next call is to jazz up my boring old beige cabinet. ■

Pentium 4 Cabinets

Intel has changed the power supply ratings for the P4 motherboards. The power supply now needs to conform to ATX 2.03 specifications. This means that most cheap cabinets using locally manufactured power supplies will not work with them. This also implies that cabinets as well as power supplies for the P4 are now imported and also cost almost double the amount that we have been used to paying. These cabi-

nets are superior in build quality (curled edges) and the quality of the power supply used. They also offer more bays and sometimes even knurled knobs instead of screws for fastening the panels of the cabinet, which makes it possible to access the insides of your system even if you do not have a screwdriver handy. Cabinets from IN-WIN have been particularly popular for P4 systems, but are costly.

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